

streamentry - the practice of awakening

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

- A Crash Course in Emptiness and Dependent Origination
  - Why Study Emptiness and Dependent Origination?
  - Fabrication
    - Examples of Fabrications
    - Proliferation
    - The Layers of Fabrication
    - The Limitations of "Mindfulness"
  - Emptiness
    - Inherent Existence
    - Illustrations
    - Fundamental Delusion
    - Common Pitfalls
    - Dependent Arising
  - Dependent Origination
    - Linear Dependent Origination
    - Non-Linear Dependent Origination
    - Subtle Dependent Origination
  - Further Study

This is an advanced course intended for experienced practitioners. If you're new to practice, we suggest you first work through the Beginner's Guide or an equivalent course.

So you've been meditating for a while, long enough to know it's the real thing: this practice is the real red pill, a path that can radically transform the human mind, leading to the end of stress and suffering and opening the door to a dimension utterly beyond the self and world that, so far, have anchored your entire experience of life.

So you're sitting, and developing your focus on the breath, or working on generating metta, or learning how to note phenomena as they rise and pass in awareness. You're also becoming familiar with notions that may still seem somewhat mysterious; terms like *insight*, *equanimity*, and *no-self*. These are starting to make more sense than they once did, but sometimes it's all still pretty confusing, so maybe you give up for now and just go back to focusing on the breath.

This is a short crash course in two of the most mysterious—yet most important—such notions: *emptiness* and *dependent origination*. These concepts are extremely deep and many-layered, so all we can do here is sketch their outlines. Nevertheless, this should prepare you to investigate them further on your own.

Why Study Emptiness and Dependent Origination?

Quite simply, because a full understanding of them leads directly to awakening, to the cessation of suffering. This understanding ultimately must be deep and intuitive, but conceptual understanding is a stepping stone, and the basis for practices that will allow you to discover deeper understanding in your direct experience.

Practice *(Collecting the Mind)*. While some of the practices we'll discuss can be done off the cushion without any special preparation, the most powerful practices involve learning to look at moment-to-moment experience in new ways when the mind is settled in meditation. The more settled, collected, energized, and happy the mind is, the more effective these practices will be. We won't give detailed instructions for collecting the mind here, because they're readily available elsewhere and because if you're reading this you almost certainly have some experience with them. Examples of practices for collecting the mind include *ānāpānasati* (awareness of the breath) and metta (generating feelings of loving-kindness).

Generally speaking, the deeper and more subtle the investigation, the more collectedness and focus is required to support it. A good rule of thumb is to plan to dedicate about 50% of each practice session to collecting the mind, and the remainder to practicing insight-oriented ways of looking. Actually, there is no hard boundary between these types of practice and one naturally learns in time to balance these two aspects, shifting the focus as called for in the moment.

A word about *attitude to practice* is in order here. The single most important thing you can do to strengthen your practice is to approach it with the right attitude. Too often we slip into habits of viewing practice as a chore, an exercise of showing up and going through the motions. Learn to view it instead as a joyful opportunity for the mind to rest, recover, and open up, and as a fascinating exploration of the patterns of this mysterious life unfolding endlessly, without and within. Take charge of this exploration, hold your lantern high, and make play and experimentation the cornerstones of your attitude to practice.

Fabrication

Fabrication (Pali: *saṅkhāra*) is a word that describes the way the mind manufactures experience. It describes both a process—the process of *fabricating*—and the results of this process—the things that *are fabricated*. This word is especially apt, because it has the sense both of something that is *constructed* and something that is *false*. As we will see, the unwitting mind continually fabricates, and mistakes its fabrications for real things. This turns out to be the root cause of binding, of all stress and suffering.

Don't think, though, that fabrication is somehow a problem. On the contrary, it's a natural process, something that minds continually do. The problem is *ignorance*—the habitual tendency to mistake fabrications for real things. When ignorance is dispelled through clear understanding of fabrication, then fabrications are seen for what they are—unreal, appearances with no substance and no power to limit or bind.

Examples of Fabrications

Let's look at some examples of fabrication. Thoughts are fabrications. So are emotions, memories, desires, and fears. Actually, everything experienced by the mind is a fabrication, something the mind plays an active part in constructing and interpreting. This isn't to say that there's no reality beyond the fabrications of the mind that gives rise, for example, to the input received by our senses. Only that the mind has no way of knowing that reality directly. Any thing that is known by the mind is the outcome of a complex series of steps in which information is rapidly filtered, added, and transformed *by the mind* to produce what we finally experience as a thought, feeling, sensation, or object. Perception itself is fabrication.

> Sorcerers say that we are inside a bubble. It is a bubble into which we are placed at the moment of our birth. At first the bubble is open, but then it begins to close until it has sealed us in. That bubble is our perception. We live inside that bubble all of our lives. And what we witness on its round walls is our own reflection. — *Carlos Castaneda's Don Juan*

Practice *(Behind the Curtain)*. A basic and important way that the mind tends to unconsciously fabricate is to abstract a complex sensory experience into a simplified, and seemingly solid, perception. This often happens with emotions, for instance. The mind may decide that a complex constellation of sensations in the throat and chest is *sadness*, and then start generating thoughts and reactions to the idea of *sadness*. Pay attention to this fabricating tendency of the mind, notice when a complex experience in the body or heart is being solidified into an abstraction, and experiment with *seeing through* that abstraction, observing that it's actually hollow, empty, without substance. Developing the ability to see behind the curtain in this way can yield deep insights into the process of fabrication.

Proliferation

generating repeating loops of thought and feeling and then reacting to those fabrications in turn, a self-fueling cycle. This kind of fabrication has a special name: *papañca* (Pali, pronounced *pah-PAHN-cha*). Papañca translates as something like *proliferation* or *amplification*, and describes the tendency of the mind to take a simple experience and generate layers upon layers of fabrication on top of it in endless, obsessive elaboration. Since you've started practicing, you've been paying more attention, and have had plenty of opportunities on and off the cushion to see this kind of proliferation and amplification in action.

You may have noticed a couple of other things too. One, proliferation tends to be closely tied up with stress and suffering: when a lot of proliferation is happening it tends to lead to stress, and also when stress is occurring, the mind tends to amplify it through proliferation. And two, when you're paying clear attention to what the mind is doing, proliferation subsides. It's as if proliferation needs you to be unaware of it to thrive: when you see the proliferating activities of the mind as just that—as just thoughts, mere fabrications without substance—those activities lose their grip and dissolve. You may not know it, but realizing these things from your own experience is a powerful, liberating insight into dependent origination.

Practice *(Dissolving Proliferation)*. On and off the cushion, maintain a light, clear background awareness of the state of the mind, and of how much proliferation is occurring. Notice the connection of proliferation to states of stress and agitation. When you notice that a lot of proliferation is arising, take a deep breath, allow your awareness to relax and expand, and simply watch the process of proliferation with quiet, steady curiosity. What happens when you do this?

The Layers of Fabrication

Fabrication has many layers. The proliferation just discussed is a relatively obvious layer, and you're probably already somewhat familiar with it from your own experience and practice. But as we've said, actually *all* experience is fabrication, including even the most subtle senses of such things as *perception*, *self*, *time*, and *awareness*. It takes more work and deeper insight to be able to recognize these very subtle and fundamental layers of mind as fabrications, but that is the goal of advanced practice. Just as papañca can't survive clear awareness, so too the seeming reality of the sense of a separate self, and even of consciousness or awareness itself, can't survive under clear and penetrating examination.

The layered nature of fabrication yields another fundamental insight: the higher layers depend on the lower ones. When a layer of fabrication dissolves, so do all the higher layers that depend on it for support. This fact has radical and immediate practical implications. *Dukkha*, stress and suffering, is like a tree with roots, a broad trunk, many branches and sub-branches, and countless clusters of leaves. We can start pruning the tree of dukkha immediately, for instance by recognizing the proliferating processes of papañca, thereby withdrawing the energy they depend on and freeing the mind to some extent. As our vision becomes more powerful through practice, ever deeper layers of fabrication are dissolved, yielding more profound and far-reaching freedom. Finally the very roots of

The Limitations of "Mindfulness"

A few words are called for here regarding the limitation of practices based primarily on "mindfulness" and "just being with what is", owing to their current popularity. These practices can be useful up to a point, as a way of becoming aware of and withdrawing energy from proliferation. A practice restricted to such an approach is, however, unlikely to provide access to the deeper forms of insight into fabrication that yield the greatest freedom. This is because such practices implicitly assume the existence of a "real reality" apart from the mind that it's *possible* just to "be with". But as we've already seen, *any form of experiencing at all is a process of fabrication that the mind plays an active part in constructing*. The default tendency of the mind is to unconsciously reify—to solidify and assign independent reality to—all layers of experience and fabrication. Unless we specifically investigate the deepest layers of our experience and see for ourselves how they're fabricated, the habitual, unconscious process of reification of these layers will continue to serve as a foundation for binding, stress, and suffering.

Emptiness

To say that something is *empty* (Pali: *suñña*) is to say that it doesn't exist as a separate, real thing in the way that it appears to. Thus, *emptiness* (Pali: *suññatā*) is a *quality*, an attribute that something may have.

Because there is an enormous amount of confusion and misinformation about the meaning of emptiness, let's first be clear about what emptiness is not:

- It is not a thing or a state of mind, mystical, meditative or otherwise.
- In particular, it is not a sense of *space* or a kind of vast, spacious awareness.
- It is not nihilism, an assertion that nothing is real or can be known.
- It is not a teaching of meaninglessness, pointlessness, or apathy.
- It is not a reference to the Unfabricated (Pali: *nibbāna*) or the experience of cessation of perception.

The English term *emptiness* is somewhat unfortunate because it tends to evoke for many people conceptions of nihilism or meaninglessness. On the contrary, deepening realization of the emptiness of phenomena leads to profound freedom of the mind and heart, and opens within us a boundless capacity for wonder and compassion. Seen with the eye that comprehends emptiness, existence appears awe-inspiring, sublime, and magical.

Inherent Existence

Emptiness is a negative concept: to say that something is *empty* is to say that it lacks something, some quality, that we ordinarily take for granted that it has. We might call this quality *inherent existence*.

that things appear to us to exist inherently and separately this way, when in fact (according to the teaching of emptiness) they do not. The teaching of emptiness thus asserts something radically and fundamentally counterintuitive about the nature of reality, something that contradicts our deepest unconscious assumptions about the way things are.

Illustrations

Suppose you're walking along a road and you turn a corner, and suddenly catch sight of a deadly snake coiled on the road in front of you, poised and ready to strike. Seeing this, you experience a surge of fear and a rush of thoughts and fabrications based on this experience. A moment later the light changes, and you realize that the "deadly snake" is actually a bundle of rope. In that moment, the fear and the whole framework of fabrication built atop it simply vanishes, dissolving like mist in sunlight.

In what sense did the snake exist? It was a construction of the mind, a fabrication with seeming substance, but in fact *empty*—existing only as an appearance, void of independent reality. Furthermore, the belief in its solid, real existence gave rise to a whole constellation of suffering—a constellation that dissolved as soon as the snake's emptiness was seen.

Consider a vivid, elaborate video game, comprising a whole world of different people and creatures and situations, all computer-generated. Seen through the eyes of a small child, a character or creature in this game might appear real, self-existent, an independent living thing interacting with other creatures and things. Thinking the world real in the way that it appears, the child might experience intense suffering if her favorite character runs into trouble. Beneath the veil of appearances, though, is a complex interconnected system of logic that, through simulation, gives rise to the whole game. What is the existential nature of a character in the game? It's *empty*—devoid of inherent, separate existence, just one of the manifestations of the logic of the underlying software.

Fundamental Delusion

Our ordinary, default intuition concerning the inherent existence of things is due to a kind of confusion, a deeply-held misapprehension woven into the very basis of the way the mind perceives and fabricates experience. We might call this misapprehension *fundamental delusion* (Pali: *avijjā*). This mistaken way of seeing is the root cause of binding, the ultimate support for the whole multi-layered edifice of fabrication that gives rise to our sense of a world of real and separate things, as well as all stress and suffering.

The purpose of the teaching of emptiness, then, is to provide a powerful tool for undermining fundamental delusion. By inquiring deeply into the nature of things in meditation, by investigating their apparent substantiality or emptiness, we gradually come to see for ourselves how the whole superstructure of appearances and fabrication is constructed. Ultimately we can become aware of the operation of fundamental delusion itself—and when we do, in that very seeing, it vanishes. What we always thought was a deadly snake—a dangerous, unpredictable world with our self caught

Common Pitfalls

One of the missteps that can sometimes occur on the path to learning about emptiness is a premature belief that you've grasped what the teachings are pointing to. Perhaps the most common way this happens is by mistaking intellectual understanding for real insight. Intellectual understanding is helpful to a degree, but is far too shallow to effect real release. This is because, as we've said, fundamental delusion is woven into the very fabric of the mind and its perceptions. We need a method of investigation that can penetrate much deeper, down to the very foundations of the usually-unconscious mind. This is the purpose of meditation. For most of us, the deep insight into emptiness required to effect profound freedom can come about only through sustained and dedicated practice.

Another common potential pitfall is to mistake a variety of interesting meditation experiences for insight into emptiness. Many meditators have heard of the idea of emptiness without understanding it, and are quick to label as "emptiness" experiences of spaciousness, expansive awareness, deep peace, or even dullness and various sorts of unconsciousness.

At times emptiness may also be confused with *unknowing*, a view that the ultimate nature of things is simply unknowable and that all we can do is stop trying to understand and just "be with things as they are". On the contrary, genuine, profound insight into emptiness is possible, and it's *insight*—clear seeing into the nature of things—that liberates.

Finally, the teaching of emptiness is profound and far-reaching, with subtleties far beyond what we are able to mention here. We have, for example, been speaking of the mind and its fabricating activities—but at a deeper level fabrication, fundamental delusion, and the mind itself are empty, void of inherent existence. The implications of statements like this cannot be fully understood until we have already seen deeply, through practice, into the emptiness of phenomena.

Dependent Arising

We've said that to say a thing is empty is to say it lacks *inherent existence*. One of the ways that a thing can be seen to lack such inherent or independent existence is to see that its existence *depends on something else*.

For example, in considering fabrication we observed that it has many layers, with higher layers depending on lower ones. In the example of the snake, misperception gave rise to fear, and fear gave rise to thoughts about the situation. The apparent reality and significance of the fear and the thoughts depended on the misperception. When the misperception was revealed, they evaporated. Similarly, the existence of the snake itself depended on misperception and *on the mind itself*. All fabrications, in fact, depend on the mind, and when we realize this in a particular case, the fabrication in question is revealed to be empty.

Another form of dependent existence—often called *dependent arising*—is when two seemingly different things actually depend on each other in order to exist. Consider, for example, the

must be the focus of attention. Thus, objects and attention are *dependent co-arisings*. Since objects depend on attention for their existence, they're actually empty; and since attention depends on an empty object for *its* existence, it's empty too. This kind of investigation can yield powerful insights when taken up in meditation.

Dependent Origination

The teaching of *dependent origination* (Pali: *paṭicca-samuppāda*) is a map that describes the stages through which *dukkha*, stress and suffering, comes into being. The map is a tool that can be used to investigate experience and fabrication, opening up possibilities for undermining, through practice, dukkha and fundamental delusion.

A common formulation of dependent origination goes like this:

> With fundamental delusion as condition, there are fabrications;
>
> With fabrications as condition, consciousness;
>
> With consciousness as condition, name and form (Pali: *nāmarūpa*) (or *mind and body*);
>
> With name and form as condition, the six sense spheres;
>
> With the six sense spheres as condition, contact;
>
> With contact as condition, feeling (Pali: *vedanā*; the sense of pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral);
>
> With feeling as condition, craving (Pali: *taṇhā*);
>
> With craving as condition, clinging;
>
> With clinging as condition, becoming;
>
> With becoming as condition, birth;
>
> With birth as condition, aging and death, sorrow, lamentation, pain, distress, and tribulation.
>
> Such is the origin of this whole mass of suffering.

The map thus describes the manner in which fundamental delusion gives rise to suffering. It's possible to get into long academic discussions about the exact meaning and scope of each of the Pali terms for the "twelve links" in this chain of dependent arising, but this is not necessary. For now, a few observations:

- We have already seen how fundamental delusion supports the build-up of layers of fabrication. One interpretation of fundamental delusion is *ignorance of emptiness and dependent origination*.
- Another meaning of fabrication here is what are sometimes called *volitional tendencies*. These are the patterns of conditioning that impel the whole process of fabrication forward. For

- Consciousness or awareness is the *faculty of knowing* sensory or mental objects.
- Name and form refer to the mental and physical dimensions of human experience.
- The "six sense spheres" include the usual five senses plus the mind.
- Contact refers to the meeting of consciousness with a sensory or mental object.
- Feeling here means, not emotion, but the very basic quality of pleasantness, unpleasantness, or neutrality that the mind registers upon coming into contact with an object.
- Craving is the mind's movement of grasping toward a pleasant object or pushing away an unpleasant object.
- Clinging is the mind's attempt to hold on to a desired object or state.
- Becoming and birth here indicate the intentions and actions, respectively, that craving and clinging give rise to. These actions in turn lead to consequences in the form of further experiences based on delusion and fabrication, and the cycle repeats. Birth can also be be understood as the solidification of a certain fabricated view, such as a view of oneself. Belief in this view is a manifestation of delusion, and the cycle continues.

As with emptiness, the teaching of dependent origination has many layers. For example, it can be understood as a process that plays out at different timescales, ranging from multiple lifetimes to the activities of the mind within a fraction of a second. Thus, seen as a process, dependent origination has a kind of fractal structure. It can also be understood at different levels of depth, from the simple to the subtle and profound.

Linear Dependent Origination

Dependent origination is often understood as a linear process unfolding in time (at various timescales). A useful, simplified version of this process is given by Culadasa in Stage Eight of *The Mind Illuminated*, and looks like this:

... → Contact → Feeling → Craving → Intention → Action → ...

where Action leads back to a new Contact and the cycle repeats.

In this model, the cycle begins with contact, the experience of consciousness coming together with a sensory or mental object. This contact leads to an impression of "pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral", which (particularly in the first two cases) leads to grasping or aversion. This leads in turn to an intention to act in accordance with the craving, and finally to the action itself. Culadasa gives this example:

> Let’s say your ears are producing a buzzing sound. You can direct your attention toward that auditory *sensation* and observe the associated *feeling* of displeasure that arises. Then, you notice that a *desire* for the sound to go away arises in response to the unpleasantness. But because you’re sitting in meditation, the only option for escape is to direct attention elsewhere, so you observe that an *intention* to redirect arises. Regardless of whether you act on that intention or not, a new *contact* event will follow. If attention doesn’t move, this whole sequence will repeat, cycling through *contact*, *feeling*, *craving*, *intention*, and *action* as part of the ongoing experience of

Practice *(Following the Links)*. Reflect on this map of dependent origination, and collect the mind in meditation. As you continue to deepen the relaxation and alertness of the mind using whatever method you choose, lightly begin also to observe the causal processes of mental fabrication; the manner in which sense impressions, thoughts, feelings, reactions, and intentions arise and pass away in dependence on one another. The more settled the mind, the more clearly and easily these causal processes can be observed. Develop in particular a sensitivity to the arising of craving—of any grasping or aversion—and watch carefully the reactions that stem from it. As always, maintain an attitude of openness, curiosity, and playful exploration as your investigations shed more and more light on how the mind works.

We may also apply the more complete version of the map to experiences on the cushion or in daily life, observing, for instance, how conditioned tendencies lead to fabrication; how fabrication captures attention (consciousness) and how the mind, reacting to fabrications, produces effects in the body (sense spheres, form); and how contact with those effects leads to grasping or aversion, impelling further actions. Observing the operation of the mind in this way, with the map of dependent origination in the background, is a practice that can lead to many insights.

Non-Linear Dependent Origination

The linear interpretation of dependent origination is useful, but often too simplistic to describe the way that experience actually unfolds. As Rob Burbea writes in *Seeing That Frees*,

> It would be more accurate if we added the realization that any link can feed into and reinforce any other link, so that all kinds of sub-loops and vicious cycles can occur.

This perspective opens up a deeper layer of the teaching of dependent origination. Now we see the "links in the chain" as more akin to nodes in an interconnected web, and can use this model to understand the ways in which the process of experience sometimes seems to cycle back and forth between two nodes or bounce back to an "earlier" stage. We may also note that often several links seem to *arise together*.

For example, consider what happens when the mind begins chasing an object of desire. Initially there is fabrication, projecting a vision or impression of the object itself, and contact with that impression. Contact is followed by pleasant vedanā, and craving arises in response. But the arising of the initial fabrication was most likely due itself to the presence of craving. And the immediate effect of craving may be to reinforce and strengthen the process of fabricating the imagined object, which in turn leads to more craving, and so on, so that these links form a loop. A similar loop may occur between craving and physical changes such as tension in the body (nāmarūpa). Or it may appear more as if craving and these patterns of contraction in the body *co-arise*.

Clearly a given process of experience can be interpreted in multiple ways according to the map, depending on how we view it. The point is not to try to find the "right" interpretation, but to explore how a knowledge of the nodes and their potential connections can shed light on our actual experiences of how dukkha arises. Most important, the map furnishes us with a variety of different

Practice *(Dissolving Clinging)*. Relax the body and collect the mind in meditation. Begin gently to become sensitive to the presence of any craving or clinging within the space of your awareness. Very often craving and clinging manifest as patterns of tension and contraction in the gross or subtle body. When you notice the presence of such tension or contraction, gently release it as much as you can. There are many ways to do this, such as simply observing it and forming the intention for it to dissolve, or allowing the area of the body that feels contracted to soften and relax. Maintain this practice of lightly and continually sensitizing awareness to clinging and then releasing any clinging you find. *Observe in particular how, once grosser forms of clinging are released, it becomes possible to notice subtler layers of clinging, and then release those.* Notice the effect that releasing clinging in this way has on the state and processes of the mind.

Practice *(Releasing Self)*. Collect the mind in meditation. Begin to expand awareness to include all body sensations. Spend a little time opening to and merging with the whole sense of the body as these sensations flow endlessly one into another. Begin then to lightly but steadily regard all body sensations as *not me, not mine*—as phenomena arising and passing away of themselves, neither part of you nor owned by you, but *just happening*, like the ceaselessly shifting patterns of weather. Just like the weather, these sensations are the outcome of an unimaginably vast web of interconnected causes and effects stretching back through time; and just like the weather, you have no control over them and they have nothing to do with you. After practicing with this view and reaching a point where you can, more or less steadily, see body sensations in this way, begin to include *thoughts* in this view as well. Thoughts also are *just happening*, forever rising and passing away—not you, not controlled by you, not owned by you. Notice the effects of this way of looking at experience on the state and processes of the mind. Can you expand this view to include other phenomena, such as feelings, too? How about attention, or awareness?

Subtle Dependent Origination

So far we have been conceiving of dependent origination as a *process unfolding in time*, whether linear or non-linear. But as we've hinted, there is something not quite right in the supposition that the twelve links are substantial things in themselves that come together to produce a real process occurring in a really-existing span of time.

Looked at more closely, the links themselves have only contingent reality, depending on one another for existence. We saw earlier, for example, how objects of our experience—nāmarūpa—depend on attention (consciousness), and also vice-versa. Another, quite surprising and significant, example of mutual dependence can be observed when the mind enters meditative states of profound letting-go. Surely clinging depends on objects of perception and vedanā, but also *objects of perception and vedanā depend on clinging*. The remaining quotations in this section are from *Seeing That Frees*:

> A meditator practising diligently will notice that, often, through many of the insight ways of looking the perception of phenomena will *fade* to some degree. It may be a little, a lot, or

another, the experience of that object under view begins to soften, blur, and fade. In the case of painful sensation, the unpleasant vedanā will also become less and less unpleasant, before the apprehension of any sensation at all gradually dissolves. Again depending in part on the background of the practitioner, this fading will initially be evident more easily in some senses than in others, but to some extent there begins to be, in meditation, a melting of all appearances, of 'things', of objects of perception.

This fading of perception – or, as Nāgārjuna and others sometimes called it, 'pacification of perception' – it is crucial to experience many, many times, and to reflect on. It is easy to miss the insight here. Without giving it a second thought, a practitioner may just assume that things disappear 'because they are impermanent', or 'because the attention is concentrating on something else'. More careful investigation, though, reveals that something more surprising, radical, and mysterious is going on here than either of these conclusions suggests: *The experience, the perception of a phenomenon, depends on clinging.* For a thing to appear as that thing for consciousness, to be consolidated into an experience, it needs a certain amount of clinging.

This insight points to the need for a still deeper understanding of dependent origination:

> Although we did acknowledge … a certain non-linearity of the links, this kind of non-linearity we are now discovering is more surprising and undermining of our common-sense notions. A seemingly basic experience is revealed to be dependent on the reaction to it. Considered from a point of view that would see the links of dependent origination as a sequence happening in time, this does not even make sense. But revealing, as it does, the emptiness of vedanā – the very experience of any sensation is revealed to be not at all independent of the way the mind is looking at it – it opens up a powerfully liberating new avenue for deeper insight.

Not only objects but the very sense of self co-arises with craving and clinging:

> In addition to making clear that dukkha depends on clinging, this way of looking also furnishes insights into the fabrication of self. As grasping and aversion clearly wax and wane in this practice, it becomes quite evident that the self-sense, too, is dependent on clinging. We can witness the sense of self moving up and down [a] continuum … more or less gross, separate, solid seeming, as craving intensifies or attenuates. When there is more push and pull with regard to phenomena, this tends to fabricate more sense of self. With less clinging, less self is built.
>
> …
>
> Self-sense, we have been saying, is dependent on clinging. But clinging is dependent on self-sense. Dependent on the sense of self, there is the wanting of this or that, or the craving for something to go away. Grasping and aversion are the normal, automatic expression of the self and its self-interest. And in fact, the more constructed the sense of self, the more the grasping and aversion that result. Without a sense of self there would be no impetus to cling. Yet we have seen just now that without clinging there can be no sense of self. Which then comes first, the clinging or the self? Are they really separate things existing inherently, on their own and independently? Can we rightly even talk of a self that does not cling, or clinging that is not born

Much more could be said on these matters, and others that lead us toward an ever deeper understanding of the map of dependent origination. We could, for example, investigate the sense of *time*, and discover that it, too, is a dependent arising, empty of the inherent existence that our intuition suggests it has. Time in fact also depends on clinging, something that we can see at an obvious level in everyday experience by comparing our time-sense when we're in an unpleasant situation as opposed to a carefree one, and at a potentially much more profound and liberating level in meditation. And of course clinging depends on time to happen in. This observation of the dependent co-arising of clinging and time opens one of many pathways into realizing the *emptiness of time*. And the emptiness of time implies, in turn, that we cannot ultimately conceive of dependent origination *as a process at all*.

But all of this is beyond the scope of this brief crash course, and even what we've said in this section may well seem, at first, more confusing than illuminating. As noted at the beginning, these are subtle matters, and the point is not to formulate a conceptual model that offers some sort of final philosophical explanation of reality. The point is freedom from dukkha, from stress and suffering, and the teachings of emptiness and dependent origination offer many paths of inquiry that lead ever deeper into that freedom. We hope you'll take from this short introduction a sense of magic, of beauty and possibility, and will be moved to explore these teachings and practices further on your own. Freedom is just the beginning.

Further Study

For a comprehensive, beautifully-written, and practice-oriented exploration of the teachings of emptiness and dependent origination, richly referenced from Theravada, Mahayana, and Tibetan sources, see Rob Burbea's book *Seeing That Frees* (2014) and the corresponding audio talks. Another valuable resource is Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu's *The Shape of Suffering: A Study of Dependent Co-Arising* (2008), based on a collection of readings from the Pali Canon.

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